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COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

National Executive Director at KPMG Believes ServiceNow's AI Solutions Drive Productivity but Face Competitive Challenges

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
25 Sep 2026	11 Sep 2026	Partner	Investor-Led (Buy-Side)	NOW

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covered the adoption and impact of ServiceNow's Now Assist and AI Control Tower, discussing their effects on productivity, licensing, deal sizes, and competition from in-house and alternative AI solutions.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- National Executive Director with extensive experience as both a consumer and implementation partner of ServiceNow and related AI solutions at large professional services firms and with clients in financial services and higher education.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- The expert believes that **while AI features like Now Assist and AI Control Tower are valuable, much of the recent revenue growth is driven by price increases** rather than organic demand.
- **The expert is cautious about the long-term incremental value of Now Assist, predicting a potential decline in usage due to competition and in-house alternatives**, but sees AI Control Tower as a promising future direction for higher-level management use cases.

TAKEAWAYS

- Now **Assist has significantly improved productivity and reduced costs for large firms**, but its adoption can lead to reduced seat counts and license contraction as fewer employees are needed.
- Deal sizes for ServiceNow projects have grown, especially among large, forward-looking clients, but this is often offset by reduced license counts and increased pricing rather than pure organic growth.
- Many clients are considering or building in-house AI solutions or leveraging other AI products (e.g., Copilot, Anthropic, ChatGPT) as alternatives to Now Assist, especially for non-ITSM use cases.
- AI Control Tower is gaining interest, particularly among C-level executives for managing technical debt and prioritizing cybersecurity and risk, but widespread adoption is still pending as many firms wait to see competitor outcomes.
- Now **Assist remains highly valuable for core ITSM use cases, where there are few viable alternatives, but faces competition in other modules** and from custom-built solutions.

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Expert Bio

National Executive Director at KPMG, former Director, ServiceNow at EY leaving in May 2026. The expert has been leading business in ServiceNow since 2019 at the Big Four, and they also lead their own practice where they sell ServiceNow products and deploy projects. They can speak to AI use cases and organizational spend. National Executive Director at KPMG. Director, ServiceNow at EY. The expert is responsible for leading enterprise ServiceNow consulting engagements, overseeing solution architecture, implementations, and platform transformation programs for large clients. They work with client stakeholders and internal teams to drive ServiceNow strategy, manage delivery of ITSM/ITOM/ITAM initiatives, and support sales, expansion, and long-term platform adoption.

Interview Transcript

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Client 00:00:00

HI there, thanks for the time. I'll try and ask my questions so that you can respond either as a customer or as an implementation partner. Our primary area of interest is Now Assist. Both from your perspective as a customer and implementation partner, are you seeing Now **Assist be genuinely incremental to ServiceNow**'s revenue? Is it more the situation where **it's offsetting some level of contraction in seats,** and so it's just netting out that impact? It would be great to just dig into that dynamic a little bit.

Expert 00:00:37

Great question. What I'll be able to do is, I'll answer it both from an internal standpoint as, let's say, a consumer at the firms that I've worked at, as well as somebody who sells projects to clients that are looking to have Now Assist embedded in their projects. I'll give a bit of color to this. I started at Deloitte in 2019. Back then, Deloitte is a consumer of ServiceNow. Internally at Deloitte, we used ServiceNow, ITSM, and at the time it was an HRSD. The lack of Now Assist then was cumbersome. It would take maybe six or seven different tabs to get a very short answer. That was the situation as a consumer within a big firm at Deloitte in 2019.

Now, I'm currently at KPMG. KPMG is also a consumer of ServiceNow. They have applied Now Assist onto HRSD. The difference is night and day. I can definitely see how, as a firm, **they are absorbing more productivity and decreasing costs** by having implemented Now Assist, and I'll explain why. Back in 2019, when I was at Deloitte, it would take me, let's say, half an hour, 45 minutes, to look for a very simple answer. This morning I had a question. I leveraged HRSD and the Now Assist feature, and it took me all of two minutes.

From a ServiceNow perspective to a KPMG or to a Deloitte, when they say Now **Assist is going to be able to increase productivity and your licenses and your adoption** will be of value, I'm walking proof that that's true.

When it comes to talking to my clients about Now Assist, I was on another call this morning that was similar to the one that we're having right now, I can't remember the last time that I had a call with clients that did not ask whether or not Now Assist came with the package, if not the additional cost, and some sort of idea for use cases and ROI on that. I'm not sure if that was the answer that you were looking for in terms of a consumer but also somebody who works within the practice.

Client 00:02:47

That's helpful. What I'm more getting at is, it seems clear that Now **Assist has a positive ROI**. When you're working with your clients, are you finding that the addition of Now Assist or the transition to their new packaging scheme, is that actually leading to larger deal sizes? Is the addition of AI netted out by smaller contracts from a seat perspective?

Expert 00:03:11

I would answer that twofold. Over the years, **the deal sizes have grown substantially because my client base has increased in terms of larger clients**. I'll further that. Right now, most of my clients are large financial services industry clients, to keep it vague. They are definitely making sure that Now Assist is embedded in the projects that they're buying simply because they are longer-term vision type clients. In other words, they want to make sure that **they are going to buy more today, dish out more money** today, so that they don't have to buy a new AI tool in a year. They understand that they're going to be spending more today so that they're spending less in a year or two. Now Assist was still around.

A few years ago, most of my clients were medium-sized businesses, they weren't necessarily ensuring that Now Assist was part of it. Therefore, **it would be a lot more hesitant to the** additional price point that Now Assist would incur when it came to deal sizes.

Client 00:04:13

Got it. If we just think about the clients you work with Now on the financial institution side, yes, they're taking on Now Assist, but are they contracting their seat counts with ServiceNow? This is the dynamic. Yes, a lot of companies are taking on AI. That's great. At the same time, are they reducing their seat count commitments because they need less people in these functions? They are more productive now. The thing I'm trying to get at is, yes, clearly Now **Assist has got good traction**, but is it truly incremental, or is it in some ways just offsetting on the other side of the ledger seat contraction?

Expert 00:04:54

I would say that it's offsetting, quite frankly. Really the only true use case, in the nontechnical term that I can reference, is a few years ago, I was dealing with a larger higher education client here in Canada that has 11 campuses actually. They implement Now Assist with the vision that their departments would use it. As a result, three years after the fact, a lot of those teams are no longer with the higher education.

Where I'm going with this is by implementing Now Assist, **they did see the higher increase in productivity**, but as a result, they're actually seeing lower adoption and lower license counts, because they don't need anybody using those licenses. Does that make any sense? Did I explain that okay?

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Client 00:05:40

That's exactly. When you look at your current client base, do you feel like they're actually spent in aggregate? Obviously, they're spending more on AI, but in aggregate, do you think that they're spending more with ServiceNow? If you look across the full portfolio, the full contract, do you get the sense that those full contracts are actually growing in size, or actually, yes, AI is going up, but other areas are actually, spend is going down just because they need less people, they're not hiring as much, etc. ?

Expert 00:06:12

I'm actually also doing my EMBA, and writing a paper on this exactly. I'm pulling from my professional experience on this. Here's what I've been seeing from a senior executive leadership perspective when I'm speaking to C-levels and so on and so forth. They need to be competitive, and therefore, most of them feel compelled to purchase Now Assist and other AI tools. **They're also feeling very compelled to put** on an AI platform, or layer, if you will, also buying AI Control Tower. For market visibility, to be competitive with their competitors, to be able to say that they're ahead and they're adopting AI, to be able to decrease licenses and other technologies that the ServiceNow layer can replace, there is that angle from a business perspective.

What they're also considering is the downstream effect. For example, I was on a call the other day and the head of development and training was on that call, and they so accurately said, "Okay, so we are going to spend all this money on adopting Now Assist, but what does that mean for my team?" As a result, more people are going to be using Now Assist, which means that we won't have new job openings, which also means that my budget for learning and training is going to decrease, because who are we going to train up when we don't have those people.

What we're seeing at a C-level layer is the messaging is it won't decrease seats, that we will train them up to use Now Assist. Now, the reality is what **they choose to do with that actual heightened productivity** because of Now Assist and AI Control Tower is up to them.

Client 00:07:49

That makes sense. **ServiceNow, in their latest earnings call, intimated that contract sizes, because of Now Assist, are growing 30%-40%** on average. They frame it as it's very much an incremental spend for most clients. Is that the experience that you are seeing with your clients?

Expert 00:08:11

It's actually not. One of the things that I would touch on is, again, I was speaking about this on an earlier call, is when we look at ServiceNow numbers, I think that **they went 20% net new ACV** this year from last year. Those are bold numbers. What they're also not necessarily mentioning is that their pricing for licenses have skyrocketed. I've been working with ServiceNow since 2019, I remember when it was arguably affordable.

Today, we are seeing a lot of debooks, and we are seeing a lot of medium-sized enterprises not necessarily going the Now Assist or AI Control Tower route. They're just getting the bare bones of ServiceNow because **boutique firms or some guy down the street are actually strong competitors in the AI game**. It's important to note that over the last three years, **ServiceNow has increased their license costs** exponentially, quite frankly.

Client 00:09:07

You think that a reasonable amount of that uplift is actually just pricing uplift rather than organic growth and demand?

Expert 00:09:14

Exactly.

Client 00:09:15

That's really interesting. Tell me more about what you're seeing in terms of the AI Control Tower. If we take your financial institution clients, would you say **most of those clients are adopting AI Control Tower**? If so, what are they using it for?

Expert 00:09:33

What I've done so far in the last year when it comes to AI Control Tower is that I've categorized them into two buckets, essentially. We've got the first bucket that are strongly looking at AI Control Tower, very interested, have biweekly calls on learning more about it, but are essentially waiting for one of their competitors to be the guinea pig. While they're waiting for one of their competitors to be the guinea pig, what they're doing is they're setting up their own center of excellence and their own AI governing body internally to get ready to deploy AI Control Tower, which is something that I always advise my clients to do. Don't let it roam free.

You got to definitely set up your own governing body for at least two years to oversee how you want it to run. You've got category one that is

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interested but not ready to take the leap. You've got category two, who have taken the leap and mainly use it for two different reasons. One, technical debt. They've noticed that over the last five to 10 years, they've purchased way too many technologies. All of their business units are using something completely different. They're completely disconnected. Now they need to find a way to have everything in one single pane, and they go with the AI Control Tower option. There's the technical debt there.

The other, when it comes to AI Control Tower, interestingly enough, are those **that are very risk adverse in the sense** that they use different modules within ServiceNow, GRC, SecOps, IRM, because they want to make sure that AI Control Tower can report on the biggest priorities, and right now in the financial industry, that is cybersecurity and risk.

What they can do with AI Control Tower is that they can set it up so that all cybersecurity and risk alerts are at the very, very top. Not to say that others don't matter, but in my conversations with clients, they're not buying AI Control Tower to see what's going on with employees or customers such as HRSD and CSM. They're really taking a look at what's going on with GRC and IRM.

Client 00:11:43

Got it. If you had to say, is AI Control Tower 10% of Now Assist or on equal terms, so 100%, where would you put it on that spectrum?

Expert 00:11:55

I think Now Assist, what we're looking at, there's no analogy that's jumping to mind, but I think that Now Assist is more for those that are in the weeds. Now Assist are for those that are in the business, on the ground. AI Control Tower is more for C-level and up. I think that we will see a decrease in Now Assist in the next year or two, for a variety of reasons. I do think that AI Control Tower is, at the risk of sounding cliché, the way of the future.

The only reason why I would challenge myself in what I just said is if a lot of companies choose not to renew other licenses of technologies that feed into AI Control Tower. That's one. The other is AI Control Tower only really works if your CMDB and your data is accurate.

Client 00:12:45

There's a bit of getting the data set ready for something like that.

Expert 00:12:49

Exactly. Let's not forget that AI Control Tower is exactly that. It's a control tower. If **you're pulling from bad data, a technology that was not set up properly, a technology that has inaccurate data or that its own AI is not being governed properly, then you're getting false information and your control tower** is getting false information. AI Control Tower, on paper it sounds great. In theory, it sounds great, but it's the practical that we all need to look out for, which brings me back to my category one of those companies that are just waiting for their competitors to be that guinea pig to see how it actually unfolds.

Client 00:13:29

That makes a lot of sense. You mentioned earlier that you think, if I heard you correctly, that **Now Assist usage will decrease in the future**. Why do you think that is?

Expert 00:13:42

I think, quite frankly, in confidence, it was a great idea quite a few years ago. I think it definitely works within ServiceNow. For the price point, I think it will decrease because of competition. I think that it's much cheaper to go with a person down the street that's all of 19 years old, but that has been coding since he was 11, that can definitely build something just as adequate as Now Assist for half the cost. I think that **a lot of firms are actually going down that route rather than overpaying for Now Assist**. That's a semi-personal opinion.

Client 00:14:17

This brings up the question, if I am a customer and I don't want to get the gold-plated Now Assist, and I want to go with something else, what are my options? I can build something in-house. Are you seeing any other vendors that are competing very well in this space?

Expert 00:14:33

A lot of vendors that I'm seeing are building their own. It's a really good question. Thanks for asking that one. One of the things that I've noticed is, two things actually. One, about two years ago, I started noticing that a lot of the clients that I deal with are building their own ServiceNow expertise in-house. What they realized is that they can build their own agents in-house, and **it's much cheaper to hire** their own, have their own, build their own agents, and then have those people govern those agents rather than go to a KPMG, or a Crossfuze, or a Deloitte to deploy the project that they can build in-house.

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What we're seeing is clients taking a look at Now Assist and saying, "Okay, that's great, but can we do it ourselves?" Number one. Two, is it cheaper if we do it ourselves. Three, is it better from a sustainability standpoint long term if we do it ourselves. There is that aspect in terms of Now Assist.

The second that I would point out is you can build your own Now Assist by using other products that most firms that I deal with already have, whether that's Copilot or an Anthropic or a ChatGPT partnership. What I'll do here is I will jump back as a consumer at the firm that I'm at and tell you that I can build my own Now Assist because I have the licenses within ServiceNow, but I'm using a Copilot AI agent because it fits my needs better, and I don't tap into the Now Assist license that I would have to ask for from my firm. That was a long-winded answer. I don't know if that brought you any value.

Client 00:16:11
That's very interesting. Sticking to your perspective as a consumer of ServiceNow, what are the trade-offs? Give me an example of where you would use Now Assist to automate a task, and you can actually just do the same thing using Copilot, like connecting up with the ServiceNow platform.

Expert 00:16:32
For example, this morning, true use case, I wanted to see just how much vacation I had left. I could go into our HRSD platform. That's step one. From there, I would have to ask the chatbot, which is Now Assist, to take a look at my vacation balance, which means it would have to look into Dayforce, and then it would have to look into my Salesforce, and then it would actually have to look into ServiceNow, and it would compile that for me. Within the chat, Now Assist would come back to me and say, I've just looked at these different sites or these different sources of knowledge, and this is your answer.

Whereas what I did within Copilot, because it has access to all of the same platforms, is I asked it, "On every month, give me a report as to how much vacation I have used up and how much will expire by November 1st." Because I can build my own within Copilot and it has access to other platforms within my firm, it was able to go ahead and do that. Now Assist is more transactional, whereas Copilot, I was able to build an AI agent that will be more long-term and repeatable.

Client 00:17:37
I can understand the use case from the perspective of your typical employee. **I would have thought the value prop of Now Assist is more, you are saving the time of the IT manager** who previously would have had to deal with 100 tickets a day, some of which just being like, "Can you help me change my password?" Now, instead 10%, 20% of those tickets can just be handled automatically through Now Assist. To me, **that's more like the core value prop of Now Assist, is the savings of the back-end functions** that would have been done by someone in IT or whatnot. Do you get the sense that people are trying to do that in-house as well?

Expert 00:18:19
We're touching on something that's super interesting here. Now Assist can be touched on different modules within ServiceNow. When it comes to ITSM, and that's a module that we would use for the instance that you had just mentioned, that cannot be replaced by a Copilot or anything like that. Now Assist is incredibly valuable for that. Quite frankly, I actually don't think that there's anything on the market that would actually compete with Now Assist when it comes to ITSM, because ITSM is quite categorized as a suite within ServiceNow. There wouldn't be a Copilot situation for that.

I think that Now Assist, when it comes to the value prop for clients, it does need to be looked at from either the only suite that you own, such as an ITSM or an HRSD, or broader, how many different modules do you actually own within ServiceNow and ensuring that Now Assist can speak to all of the different modules that you have.

Client 00:19:15
Got it. You think definitely in the core ITSM use case, Now Assist is very valuable and will continue to be so?

Expert 00:19:23
Yeah, very much so, very much so. I think that it also comes down to the purpose. For example, if I'm in IT and I'm getting asked by certain departments for a password reset 150 times a day, the Now Assist will be able to power that out, quite frankly, very quickly. You wouldn't even need a human to touch that. If you're using Now Assist for HRSD, le**t's say, and there's an ongoing dispute about a paycheck situation**, what Now Assist will be able to do is to take all the different chats, all of the phone calls, emails, exchanges that the firm has had with an employee, and be able to create resolution notes and then tell the agent how to best handle that situation.

That would be from an internal standpoint, but if me as a user of Now Assist within the firm, not somebody who is deploying it, not

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somebody who is looking to solve the problem, but the person who is bringing the problem, would be one way of looking at it, I would not go ahead and try to use Now Assist to help me on that. I would go ahead and build my own agent.

Client 00:20:29

That makes sense. You've been working with ServiceNow in various capacities for several years. Would you say its brightest days are behind it or ahead of it as a business?

Expert 00:20:43

I think about that every day, sir, or maybe not every day, but on the weekly. I don't think its brightest days are behind us. I think they're on the right path when it comes to listening to client needs. I think going ERP, and the AI Control Tower, was needed. A lot of people say it was a bold move. I actually don't agree with it. I think it was a needed move. **I do, however, think their strongest challenge** is going to be pricing. We live in a market where smaller technology companies can deliver the same value as ServiceNow. Can they deliver the same integrity and brand and reputation, no, but we're shifting.

We're seeing a world where we are more trusting of the smaller technologies rather than the big Walmarts, the big Costcos, the big ServiceNows. Where that goes, we'll see, but it's always a safe bet. I say that because all of my clients are repeat customers. **I've never lost one large client** because they are going with somebody who has been able to build something down the road. The risks are just too great. I believe that has something to do with the type of clients that I have. They're not willing to take that risk, nor should they.

It will be interesting to see just how much ServiceNow innovates, because that is the guiding light for all technology companies nowadays, is how quickly can you innovate and how quickly can you prove your innovation to be successful.

Client 00:22:13

That would be great. All right. Thanks. This has been really helpful. I appreciate the time.

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